Indian officials were concerned that while China loomed large for Delhi, superpower differences on cuts and verification related to a nonproliferation treaty were sidetracking the question of the security of nonnuclear states.[221] This concern only increased after another Chinese nuclear test in May 1966. Gandhi told Johnson about the renewed domestic calls in India for a nuclear weapons program and that "each fresh report of China's activity in this regard strengthens this demand and attracts new adherents to it."[222]

At a National Security Council meeting after the test, Johnson expressed concern about the political pressure on the Indian government to acquire a nuclear bomb. He believed such a development would adversely affect India's economy and Asian stability. Participants considered various options to prevent an Indian nuclear weapons program, including economic pressure, a US-Soviet arms control agreement that could reduce the Indian need to get a bomb, or bilateral or multilateral security guarantees to India. Humphrey suggested UN assurances combined with private US assurances, which would mean the Soviet Union could join if it wanted to, India would not feel pressured publicly to attach itself to the US, and the Soviet Union would not have to object. There was, however, little consensus on what route to take. Rostow noted that the US needed to "to buy time until the Indians came to accept the necessity for Western assistance."[223] Johnson subsequently approved the further exploration of alternative courses of action.[224]

That examination, however, was unsatisfactory, concluding, "We have been unable to devise anything dramatic which would not cost us more than any anticipated gain." It only recommended further study while the US formulated broader nonproliferation steps.[225] In the meantime, a State Department paper recommended sharing intelligence on the Chinese nuclear program with India, especially highlighting its shortcomings. Furthermore, it suggested emphasizing to Indian officials the costs of a nuclear weapons program, while simultaneously working with them to find ways to increase Indian prestige. It also recommended thinking of ways to link economic assistance to an Indian pledge not to go nuclear. In addition, the paper suggested working with Moscow to formulate UN assurances to nonnuclear weapons states and come up with an arms control agreement. The paper did also call for further studies on how to assure India credibly,